

# Long-Tail AI Companies - Force-Ranked Reading List

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## Force-Ranked Reading List — Long-Tail AI Companies (< 500 employees)

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From the 97 companies in the job inventory, I removed anything clearly >500 or already covered earlier in this project (Fleet, Surge, Mercor, Snorkel, Decagon, Sierra, Harvey, the frontier labs, etc. — you've read those), leaving **40 genuinely long-tail names**. Each was enriched (real headcount, funding, traction) and scored 1–5 on four axes tuned to your profile — **role fit** (non-SWE PM/deployment/research), **profile leverage** (does the work reward customer discovery + qualitative research + domain writing + ops), **coding-lightness**, **traction/health** — plus an obscurity bonus. **5 were cut for exceeding 500 employees**, leaving **35 ranked below**. Run 2026-07-02.

**Notability key:** ● obscure · ◐ somewhat-known · ○ known (you may have seen it).

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### Start here — the hidden gems (obscure + high-fit)

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If you only read about five, read these. Each is small, under-the-radar, and the open role is squarely non-SWE customer-discovery/deployment/research work:

1. **Amigo** (healthcare clinical agents, ~35, NYC) — The *AI Deployment Strategist* is explicitly the **non-engineering half of a two-person deployment pair** (paired with an agent engineer): map clinical workflows, own safety/quality framing, run delivery. Almost a job description of your profile. *Watch-out: NYC-onsite*.
2. **Forerunner** (GovTech / flood-risk geospatial, ~80, NYC, **remote**) — Remote *Deployment Strategist* rolling software out to local governments: B2G customer discovery, stakeholder synthesis, delivery. Mission-driven, and remote clears your geo bar cleanly.
3. **Auctor** (AI for enterprise-software *implementation*, ~25, NYC, remote) — Founded 2025, so the *Deployment Strategist* AND *Founding Product Operations Manager* are both open and both are pure discovery-workflow-delivery-ops. Their whole product automates the FDE/solutions-engineer job — you'd be shaping the function from the ground floor. *High ambiguity (very young/tiny)*.
4. **Forge** (rebranded **Poetic**; enterprise process automation, ~30, SF) — *Forward Deployed Strategist* owning strategic enterprise accounts (adoption, expansion) under ambiguity. SF, so onsite works for you.
5. **Percepta** (General Catalyst's in-house applied-AI company, ~30, NYC) — The role that inspired this whole search. *Research Product Manager, Embedded PM, Embedded Researcher, Chief of Staff* — an unusually clean four-way match to product-research + intelligence + ops. NYC, and a high-prestige bar.

Runners-up worth the read: **Tailor** (composable ERP for AI agents, remote FDPM), **Tribe AI** (AI-services *Delivery Lead* — pure program-ops, remote), **FERMÀT** (AI-native D2C commerce — your D2C discovery background), **Lorikeet** (AI support concierge, remote FDPM), **Siena AI** (autonomous CX, remote FDPM).

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### The full force-ranked list (35 companies < 500 employees)

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Ranked by fit to your experience; obscurity breaks near-ties. **Fit** = composite score. **HC** = est. headcount.

| #  | Company                           | Fit | Notab.  | HC  | Vertical                     | Why it fits YOU                                                                                                            | Watch-out                                                             |
|----|-----------------------------------|-----|---------|-----|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | <b>OpenEvidence</b>               | 42  | ◦ known | 130 | Healthcare AI / clinical ... | Both open roles fit this candidate cleanly: the Client Success Manager maps to program/delivery/ops management, and the... | Hyper-growth and lean headcount mean high bar and intense pace; h...  |
| 2  | <b>Amigo</b>                      | 42  | ◦ some  | 35  | Healthcare (clinical pati... | The AI Deployment Strategist role is explicitly the non-engineering half of Amigo's deployment pair (paired with a sepa... | Geography: the open role is NYC/onsite, but the candidate wants S...  |
| 3  | <b>Forerunner</b>                 | 42  | ◦ some  | 80  | GovTech / geospatial inte... | This is a near-ideal match: a remote Deployment Strategist rolling out software to government agencies demands exactly ... | Smaller total funding (\$39M) and slower public-sector (B2G) sales... |
| 4  | <b>Auctor</b>                     | 42  | ◦ some  | 25  | Enterprise software imple... | Near-ideal: the Deployment Strategist and Founding Product Operations Manager roles are exactly customer-discovery, wor... | Very young (founded 2025) and tiny, so roles are high-ambiguity/h...  |
| 5  | <b>Axion (formerly Axion Ray)</b> | 42  | ◦ some  | 320 | Industrial / manufacturin... | The 'AI Deployment Strategist' on the Solutions/Delivery team is exactly a non-SWE deployment/PM role: drive adoption, ... | Headcount already ~300+ so growth room to 500 is limited; role li...  |
| 6  | <b>Forge (rebranded Poetic)</b>   | 42  | ◦ some  | 30  | Enterprise process automa... | The Forward Deployed Strategist role is customer-facing ownership of strategic enterprise accounts (adoption, expansion... | Company recently rebranded Forge -> Poetic, so the 'Forge' job po...  |
| 7  | <b>Lorikeet</b>                   | 42  | ◦ some  | 89  | AI customer support / CX ... | The Forward Deployed Product Manager role is built to establish post-sales strategy: acting as a trusted AI advisor to ... | None major; role is senior/function-building so expects someone c...  |
| 8  | <b>Fractional AI</b>              | 41  | ◦ known | 82  | Applied AI / forward-depl... | The Forward Deployed Product Manager / Associate FDPM roles are explicitly PM/deployment positions — customer discovery... | Company is 'engineering-first' and prizes 'engineering excellence...  |
| 9  | <b>FERMAT (FERMÀT Commerce)</b>   | 41  | ◦ some  | 70  | AI-native commerce / D2C ... | A Forward Deployed Product Manager role is nearly ideal for this candidate: heavy B2B/D2C customer discovery, embedding... | FDPM roles can carry a quota/customer-success edge and some light...  |
| 10 | <b>Percepta</b>                   | 41  | ◦ some  | 30  | Applied AI / enterprise A... | This is an unusually clean match: the open roles (Chief of Staff, Embedded Product Manager, Research Product Manager, E... | All four roles are NYC onsite/hybrid, which conflicts with the ca...  |
| 11 | <b>Tailor</b>                     | 41  | ◦ some  | 50  | Composable / 'headless' E... | The Forward-Deployed Product Manager role is almost a one-to-one match for this candidate: extracting requirements from... | Requires understanding of ERP/API concepts (technical-adjacent, n...  |
| 12 | <b>Tribe AI</b>                   | 41  | ◦ some  | 90  | Horizontal AI consulting ... | Near-ideal: the Delivery Lead role is pure program/operations management (milestone tracking, program health RAG status... | Only lightly funded (\$3.25M seed) and services-margin business, s... |

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|----|--------------------------------|-----|-----------|-----|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 13 | <b>Siena AI</b>                | 40  | • some    | 45  | Autonomous AI customer se... | The Forward Deployed Product Manager, Agents role is an excellent match: it centers on D2C/e-commerce customer discover... | Only seed-stage with modest ~\$4.7M funding in a crowded AI-CS mar... |
| 14 | <b>Northslope Technologies</b> | 39  | • some    | 100 | Applied AI / forward-depl... | The Deployment Strategist role is a classic forward-deployed / FDE-adjacent position centered on customer discovery, un... | Hub offices are NYC/London/Denver, not SF Bay, and the role is de...  |
| 15 | <b>David AI</b>                | 39  | • some    | 47  | Audio/voice AI training d... | The Deployment Strategist is a customer-facing, consultative role: partner with senior stakeholders on their audio AI i... | SF onsite only (candidate accepts this). Fast headcount growth me...  |
| 16 | <b>HappyRobot</b>              | 39  | • some    | 152 | Logistics / supply chain ... | The Deployment Strategist role is essentially a forward-deployed PM: dive into customer operations, do discovery with e... | Logistics/supply chain domain may be unfamiliar to the candidate;...  |
| 17 | <b>Pallet</b>                  | 39  | • some    | 80  | Logistics / supply chain ... | Deployment Strategist is a customer-facing implementation role (map customer workflows, configure/onboard AI agents, dr... | The AI-team Deployment Strategist per the GC job board is NYC in-...  |
| 18 | <b>AfterQuery</b>              | 39  | • some    | 30  | AI training data / applie... | The (non-coding) Strategic Projects Lead sits with the founding team across product, research, and operations — a near-... | Two variants of the role exist — a 'Technical Strategic Projects ...  |
| 19 | <b>Dealops</b>                 | 38  | ● obscure | 17  | B2B pricing & CPQ / reven... | The Forward Deployed Strategist leads client-facing projects implementing AI pricing/deal workflows — heavy on B2B cust... | Very early and small (\$7M seed, ~17 people) — more stage risk tha... |
| 20 | <b>Prosper AI</b>              | 38  | • some    | 50  | Healthcare operations — A... | The 'AI Product Manager' role is a strong match: deploying voice agents in healthcare demands heavy customer discovery ... | HQ is New York, not SF Bay, and remote policy is unconfirmed (can...  |
| 21 | <b>Context</b>                 | 37  | • some    | 30  | Horizontal productivity /... | A 'Deployment Strategist' is a Palantir-style forward-deployed, customer-facing role — heavy on customer discovery, wor... | Very early (seed, ~2024) so small team and higher volatility; hea...  |
| 22 | <b>Onebrief</b>                | 36  | • some    | 345 | Defense tech / military o... | The open role is a Staff Product Manager, Applied AI (Remote) — a genuine non-coding PM seat that rewards this candidat... | Defense-tech may involve security-clearance or ITAR constraints; ...  |
| 23 | <b>Profound</b>                | 35  | ○ known   | 180 | AI marketing / martech — ... | The 'Product Manager, AI' role suits a PM who runs B2B customer discovery and synthesizes qualitative signal; martech/A... | HQ is New York (candidate wants SF Bay onsite or fully remote) an...  |
| 24 | <b>Ema</b>                     | 35  | • some    | 180 | Horizontal enterprise age... | The Product Manager opening rewards the candidate's core strengths — B2B customer discovery, qualitative synthesis, dom... | Task brief labeled this 'Series B' but it is actually Series A — ...  |
| 25 | <b>Sema4.ai</b>                | 35  | • some    | 60  | Enterprise AI agents / ba... | Both openings are Product Manager roles (Document Intelligence; Enterprise AI Agents) that reward B2B customer discover... | 'Technical Product Manager' title may skew more technical than th...  |

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|----|------------------------------------|-----|---------|-----|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 26 | <b>Tessera Labs</b>                | 34  | • some  | 55  | Enterprise AI for ERP mod...  | The Product Manager role fits a PM/research profile — product strategy, market analysis, use-case prioritization, and c... | PM role is described as technically hands-on (data science / engi...  |
| 27 | <b>Redox</b>                       | 34  | ◦ known | 190 | Healthcare data interoper...  | Senior Product Manager II for AI Platform & Agentic Experience is a strong non-SWE PM fit that rewards B2B customer dis... | Headcount has drifted down from earlier peaks (~200+), suggesting...  |
| 28 | <b>Peregrine Technologies</b>      | 34  | ◦ known | 440 | Public safety / law enfor...  | The Deployment Strategist role is a forward-deployed, customer-facing delivery job (Palantir-style) that rewards custom... | Deployment Strategist work at a data platform typically involves ...  |
| 29 | <b>Paradigm</b>                    | 32  | • some  | 12  | Horizontal productivity / ... | A Business Operations Generalist at a ~10-person startup is a broad, no-code seat covering delivery, program coordinati... | Very early (seed, ~\$7M, ~10 people) so higher startup risk and a ... |
| 30 | <b>Runlayer</b>                    | 31  | • some  | 20  | AI agent / MCP (Model Con...  | Founding Product Manager (remote) is a genuine PM role heavy on customer discovery and defining product direction — goo... | Very early-stage (<~30 people, seed/Series A) means role ambigu...    |
| 31 | <b>Factory.ai</b>                  | 30  | ◦ known | 120 | AI coding agents / enterp...  | Deployment Strategist is a forward-deployed, customer-facing solutions role (adoption, discovery, delivery) that maps w... | Coding-tools domain expects hands-on technical/engineering fluenc...  |
| 32 | <b>Augment (goAugment / Augie)</b> | 28  | • some  | 130 | Supply chain / logistics ...  | The PM roles are 0-1 product work with heavy customer/operator discovery in a specific domain (logistics), which reward... | Disambiguation: this is goAugment (supply-chain), NOT Augment Cod...  |
| 33 | <b>Crew AI (CrewAI)</b>            | 25  | ◦ known | 74  | AI agent orchestration / ...  | CrewAI is a Python agent framework, so its Forward Deployed / AI Deployment Engineer roles are genuinely engineering-ti... | Both open roles are 'Engineer' titles at a code-framework company...  |
| 34 | <b>Lyzr</b>                        | 24  | • some  | 170 | Horizontal enterprise AI-...  | The listed role is an Associate PM (Applied AI) based in Bengaluru onsite, which fails the candidate's SF Bay/fully-rem... | Only open role found is Bengaluru onsite - hard geo mismatch for ...  |
| 35 | <b>Ascertain</b>                   | 23  | • some  | 28  | Healthcare (agentic AI fo...  | The Forward Deployed Engineer role has a strong customer-discovery / workflow-mapping component the candidate would exc... | Role requires shipping production code daily (integrations, platf...  |

## Cut by the 500-employee filter (5)

Strong-fit roles, but too big per your rule — skip for this pass:

- **Abridge** (~605; healthcare ambient clinical AI) — *Founding FDPM* would've ranked top-3 on fit; a16z-backed, \$5.3B. Just over the line.
- **EvenUp** (~835; legal-tech AI) — many remote PM/TPM roles, but well past 500.
- **EliseAI** (~599; housing/property AI) — right at the boundary and climbing.
- **Caylent** (~897; AWS-partner AI consultancy).

- **cBEYONData / SMX** (~2,000; govtech systems integrator).
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## How to read this list (and its limits)

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- **Well-known** ● → ○ **note:** a few high scorers are *not* obscure — **OpenEvidence** (#1 on raw fit, but a hyped clinical-AI name you've probably seen), **Fractional AI**, **Factory.ai**, **Profound**, **Redox**, **Peregrine**, **Crew AI**. They're kept because they're <500 and fit, but if "discover something new" is the goal, weight the ●/○ rows.
- **The coding trap persists in the tail:** **Ascertain** and **Crew AI** rank low because their open roles are genuinely engineering-heavy despite forward-deployed titles — correctly demoted.
- **Geography:** many top gems are NYC (Amigo, Forerunner, Auctor, Percepta) or international (Tailor–Tokyo, Lorikeet–Sydney). Remote-friendly high-fit options: Forerunner, Tribe AI, Tailor, Lorikeet, Siena, Forge remote variants.
- **Headcount confidence varies** — several are estimates from Crunchbase/Tracxn/ LinkedIn (flagged medium/low in the source data); boundary cases (Peregrine ~440, Onebrief ~345, Axion ~320) are comfortably under 500 but worth re-checking.
- **Full enriched data** (funding, investors, sources, all four sub-scores per company) is in `longtail-companies-enriched.csv`.